

One of the biggest challenges the pandemic posited on broadcast media was on how to generate content. Throughout the progress of the pandemic, content producers were forced either to recycle or find alternatives to continuously provide entertainment that will assuage the devastation we are experiencing at the very least. On top of it all, the impeccable rendition of Thailand Boy's Love (BL) series had revolutionized the Philippine broadcasting landscape by introducing the genre that would later look into the plight of Filipino same-sex couples.

Although Thailand had the reputation for producing flawless BL series, the genre's origins could be traced back in Japan's tradition of tolerance for homoerotic series (Watson & Jirik, 2018). In the Philippines, it began when The Idea First Company commenced the BL series "GameBoys" starred by Elijah Canlas and Kokoy De Santos who both identify as *cisgender males in real life. The storyline revolves around two teenagers who developed fondness of each other's company while playing online games and eventually fell in love with one another (Bigtas, 2020). Towards the end of the year, Globe Studios introduced *Gaya sa Pelikula* or GSP (Like in The Movies) which narrates the journey to self-discovery of Karl, a closeted gay and aspiring film student who was enchanted by destiny to meet Vlad an openly gay, male identifying film student. Their spontaneous affection of each other perplexed Karl and led him to question his identity. Both actors identify as *cisgender males behind the screens. Both series demonstrated the long-standing, concurrent, and overlapping struggles of the community while taking into account the nuances of everyday experience of an LGBTQIA couple.

Indeed, the introduction of BL series in emerging media channels like YouTube had a huge impact not only on broadcasting media but also on the plight of the sexual minority group it represents. But to fully understand its impact, it is imperative to look at it on a micro scale and analyze its technical side.

Even though political leaders had little influence on the selection of artists, directors, and production staff, persons of high economic power had. And this is problematic. Most of the protagonists were good looking, popular, and cisgender. The preferences of the elites influence the development and direction of what the audience consume, which product the consumers patronize, and who they identify with. Additionally, the fact that cisgender males were chosen to represent LGBT characters and several heterosexual writers to write the scripts display power.

Even if there are genuine representations and adept writers that experienced first-hand the plight of the community, if they are not commercially viable, they are not the best option.

Not only did the elites have the upperhand. During the peak of the BL series, various groups launched their own BL series starring giant and fresh personalities, who happened to have fandoms. Take for example Kokoy de Santos from GameBoys who have previously done LGBT-themed movies. His great acting skills and experience with LGBT characters made viewers anticipate his stint in GameBoys. In GSP, having Juan Miguel Severo who is a member of the LGBT community and vocal advocate of equality, had a good pitch with Globe Studios, and allowed him to broadcast the series. In both instances, the audience displayed power on which series to support and consume. A classic example of the antagonism between political economy and audience.

To the LGBT community's delight, during the 17th Congress the SOGIE Equality Bill was approved on its final reading, however was cut short because of the Senate's disinterest. Its coexistence with the momentum of BL series in the Philippines and the lobbying of the SOGIE Equality Bill for the second time led to a more meaningful consumption and potent media mileage. Consequently, advocates seized the opportunity to voice out their calls for equality through emerging media and socially relevant content particularly in GSP. Again, remaining true with the fundamental principle of content that content adapts with the situations, politics, and economy of that particular period.

Consistent with the classification of genre theory, I argue that BL series fall into several genres and formats. It is a drama series because it follows the usual number of episodes and the specific airtime of 20-40 minutes per episode. In addition, the series could also be considered as educational since it not only presents the plight of the sexual minority group, but also illustrates how the current cultural norms, beliefs, and systems affect them. In GSP, Vlad confronted his sister with how her words traumatized him as child (*"Dahil sa iyo [pagiging bakla], iniwan tayo ni Papa"*). This scene sends a message to the viewers that words and actions towards the LGBTQIA had negative repercussions which they carry for a lifetime.

Another factor which contributed to the success of both series was their programming. For the principle of selection, Globe Studios was the major producer of GSP and Gameboys was produced by the Idea First Company. These were established companies with a wide and

competitive market. The principle of scheduling states that it has a specific timeslot and timespan. Both GSP and GameBoys run for two months with 8 episodes each, aired during 8PM of Fridays. Posters were used to disseminate information and several virtual press conferences were conducted to promote the series. Furthermore, the use of YouTube (as content and ad) as the major platform to access them, also contributed to reaching more people. YouTube respects agency of the audience to watch it whenever and whichever device available to them. Lastly, both series were evaluated by sponsors. That new seasons will be launched imminently and would be made available in different digital platforms like NetFlix and iFlix.

This was a challenging year. Despite all fears sowed, hope was delivered by the broadcast media. Proven by time, broadcast media holds a vital role in directing our country's progress and shaping and empowering lives especially the most vulnerable and underrepresented by the content it delivers.

The forward progression of media is inevitable. And my hope for equality and acceptance is the same.

#

* there was no disclosed information regarding the sexuality of actors as of writing.

REFERENCES

Bigtas, J., A. (2020, June 17). The first Filipino BL series “Gameboys” attracts more than 1.5M views on YouTube. *GMA News Online*. Retrieved from [The first Filipino BL series 'Gameboys' attracts more than 1.5M views on YouTube \(gmanetwork.com\)](https://www.gmanetwork.com/news/story/804444/entertainment/television/the-first-filipino-bl-series-gameboys-attracts-more-than-1-5m-views-on-youtube)

Watson, J., & Jirik, K. (2018, June 20). Boy's love: The unstoppable rise of same-sex soapies in Thailand. *ABC Radio National*. Retrieved from [Boys' love: The unstoppable rise of same-sex soapies in Thailand - ABC News](https://www.abc.net.au/news/2018-06-20/boys-love-the-unstoppable-rise-of-same-sex-soapies-in-thailand/10000000)